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THE ANCIENTS

A few years ago *Isis*, the journal of the History of Science Society, devoted a special section to 'The Cultures of Ancient Science'. Most of the articles in that section focused on the problem of 'Greek Science' and its relationship to modern science (Lloyd, 1992; Pingree, 1992; von Staden, 1992). There was a clear consensus that more recent historical scholarship was quite incompatible with nineteenth- and earlier twentieth-century views that credited the Greeks with the invention of science. Not only had the meaning of 'science' and all its categories changed fundamentally, but there was little or no historical continuity to be discovered between then and now. Nowadays, we have become much more ready to accept the Ancients on their own terms, rather than turning to them for a spurious origin of our own notions. Ancient science is fascinating in its own right. We demean it in the service of dangerous myths of Western origins if we simply mine it for fanciful 'anticipations' of our own ideas.

As already indicated in Chapter 1, we face a similar issue in the historiography of psychology. Because Aristotle was responsible for a book about 'the soul', he was long credited with being the first to write systematically about psychology. Textbooks on the history of psychology commonly begin with the Greeks, ignoring the fact that the very notion of 'psychology' in the modern sense, forming a distinct field of study, can hardly be said to have existed before the eighteenth century (see Chapter 3).

Such cavalier treatments of the highly problematic question of historical continuity usually rely on an uncritical equation of ancient and modern categories. But when they were translated from Greek into Latin and from Latin into various modern languages the categories employed by Aristotle and his compatriots profoundly changed their meaning, not to speak of the changes that occurred within one language over the centuries. Thus, Aristotle's *psyche* is not the *anima* of his Latin translators, and even less is it the *soul* of the Middle Ages, let alone the *mind* of the moderns. Less inclusive categories underwent similar profound changes, if only because the entire conceptual network of which they formed a part had changed (Danziger, 1990b).

There are therefore strong grounds for not including the ancient

period in any history of psychological language. However, there are also reasons for devoting at least some attention to this topic. First, there is the existence of an unfortunate tradition in the historiography of psychology, already referred to. Because that tradition has been biased so heavily in favour of historical continuity, some of the more glaring discontinuities should at least be mentioned in order to restore some balance. I do not wish to deny the existence of all historical continuity in principle. My position is that continuity must be rigorously demonstrated rather than assumed, and that it has certainly not been demonstrated in the examples discussed in this chapter.

A second reason for spending a little time with the Ancients is more important. It is a reason that will still be valid when the last traces of the old distortions have disappeared. Nowadays, we accept that knowledge of other cultures, in other parts of the world, can tell us quite a lot about ourselves. By studying the differences between them and us we gain insights, not only into their world, but also our own. Aspects of our own culture, that we had taken completely for granted and hardly been aware of, now move into prominence and change our view of ourselves. We look to social anthropology to provide such insights. But there are cultures, capable of presenting us with a valuable sense of 'otherness', which are conventionally studied by historians rather than by anthropologists. These cultures are separated from us by time rather than by space, and so the methods for studying them are somewhat different. But although we cannot interview or observe their members, the texts and artefacts they left behind often allow us to enter into a fascinatingly different conceptual and material world. That can be a valuable antidote to one great danger attending the reign of 'behavioural science', namely, that its historically contingent and culturally parochial categories will be mistaken for universal principles having eternal validity.

About three centuries ago, there occurred the beginnings of the conceptual changes necessary for the emergence of psychology in the modern sense. In terms of the history of psychology this was a revolutionary development. Before this point, nothing like modern psychology had even been thinkable; afterwards it was. Before this time, there was no network of categories within which a space for the possibility of psychology in our sense could open up. In the next chapter I will describe the new categorical framework from which there is a continuous line of development up to the twentieth century. But because this framework is so deeply embedded in modern culture, it tends to have an obviousness, a taken for granted quality, that makes it difficult to step outside it. To appreciate the fact that it replaced a very different framework, it is necessary to step back in time, even if only briefly, in order to get some sense of a few of the alternative conceptualizations that once existed.

In pursuit of this limited goal I will concentrate on three interconnected topics. First, there is the question of human persons becoming

objects to themselves. That question lies behind much of the confusion about the supposedly ancient roots of psychology. Psychological discourse presupposes that individuals have learned to relate to themselves in some sense as objects, that they have learned to introspect their own mental states, or self-consciously monitor their own actions, or describe their own character traits in a common language. These are all examples of *psychological* self-objectification. For us, they are the most familiar examples. For that reason we should guard against the temptation to interpret *all* cases of self-objectification psychologically, assuming that all self-objectifying discourse is necessarily psychological discourse. This is the error we are invited to make by many historical treatments of the ancient roots of psychology. The Ancients certainly developed ways of thinking and acting reflexively, but only by looking at these practices will we be able to decide how close they came to modern psychological reflexivity.

The second topic singled out for attention is that of reason. That is because some of the most fundamental differences between ancient and modern conceptions about people revolve around this category. These differences are discussed in the next chapter. For the present, it will suffice to prepare the ground by means of illustrative examples from the ancient vocabulary pertaining to human reasoning. These will all be taken from one source of unique historical importance, the Aristotelian texts. The content of those texts was very much alive in the period immediately preceding the conceptual transformation to be discussed in the next chapter.

If reason constituted one pole around which ancient self-objectifying discourse revolved, the affections or passions constituted the other. Although these were perhaps the most obvious 'psychological' categories in the classical texts, they faded away and died precisely at the time that the modern psychological categories began to achieve prominence. The reasons for this discontinuity will be explored in the next chapter. Here it will simply be a question of selecting enough background information to provide a point of departure for a consideration of modern developments.¹

Persons as objects to themselves

One way of dividing up the use of psychological categories is by personal pronoun (Shotter, 1990). We can give accounts in the first person, explaining our actions by reference, for example, to an individual intention. We can also address another person, and perhaps attribute to them a particular belief or fear. Or we can talk in the third person, describing an individual, or something about an individual, just as we might describe any other kind of object. As already indicated, our interest is in the genesis of categories used in the objective mode.

We are accustomed to a plentiful supply of such categories, and we readily transfer them to the first or second person mode. Anyone may refer to themselves or their partner as being an extrovert, or having dependency needs, for example. That involves a kind of self-objectification which we have come to take for granted. But we should not assume that it could be taken for granted at all times. If we read Homeric and other ancient texts attentively we will be struck by the absence of references to the internal mental states of characters (Jaynes, 1976; Snell, 1953) and by what has been called their 'unreflective awareness of "self"' (Sullivan, 1988). At this point, self-objectification seems either to be rudimentary or to assume forms that are quite alien to us. A considerable distance separates the impetuous Homeric heroes from the intellectually sophisticated pupils of Aristotle. Was anything of psychological relevance involved in this change?

The Ancients may well have taken important steps towards self-objectification, but this does not mean that the specific categories they used for constructing self-objects were anything like the psychological categories we know. The mistake commonly made in histories of psychology is the assumption that all self-objectification must necessarily be psychological in character. That assumption is distinctly implausible in the case of the Ancient Greeks, because their language lacked not just some but virtually all the key substantives that define modern discourse on this topic. There were no words for 'the self', for 'mind', for 'consciousness'; and other key words had meanings very different from the meanings they acquired closer to our own time (Wilkes, 1988). 'Psyche', or soul, for example, was something that a tree or even a magnetic substance could have. This means that we run the risk of seriously misinterpreting classical Greek texts if we simply assume without more ado that they constitute a discourse about 'the self', as that term is understood today.

In the course of exploring the historical constitution of the ethical subject Michel Foucault (1986) directed attention to a considerable classical literature on the topic of self-care. This literature is part of, and emerges out of, a more extensive body of writing on the good life, on how to conduct oneself in order to live a life worth living. Such a project entails a reflexive examination of one's own conduct. But making one's conduct an object of scrutiny is not the same thing as separating a substantial self from its actions. For that there would have to be a clear distinction between an individual's actions and some entity assumed to exist apart from and behind those actions. What we get in the classical literature is the reflexive form 'caring for oneself' (*epimeleia sautou*). Although the subtitle of Foucault's volume, 'The care of the self', seems to imply a substantive self concept, that is not what is intended: 'The care of the self is the care of the activity and not the care of the soul-as-substance' (Foucault, 1988: 25). Foucault's primary interest lies in the historical constitution of the self in the sense of an ethical

subject. But his main access to this topic is through an analysis of the literature of self-care. He therefore uses the term 'the self' in two senses: in reference to a postulated subject of moral action, and in reference to something that is addressed in the relevant classical literature. The latter is not to be equated with the modern, psychological, self concept, as we will see.

Foucault identifies some features of a process by which persons gradually became objects for themselves. The classical ideal of knowing oneself developed in the context of specific practices of acting on oneself, referred to by him as 'technologies of the self' (Foucault, 1988). Such 'technologies' included, for example, the keeping of a diary and the writing of letters to friends in which a degree of self-disclosure was systematically aimed at. However, we must be careful not to exaggerate the degree of self-disclosure involved here: this type of writing 'stresses what you did, not what you thought' (Foucault, 1988: 30). It takes the writer's past and future actions as its object, not the writer as an entity beyond those actions.

It should also be noted that in taking one's own actions as an object one was engaging in a *social* practice. This is quite obvious in the case of letter writing, but keeping a diary meant following known rules regarding its form and content and often engaging in a kind of imaginary or postponed communication with some other. Quite generally, self-reflection relied on the guidance of another person recognized as being specially equipped for this role. An early prototype for such a relationship is presented in the Platonic dialogues, most explicitly in Alcibiades I, in which Socrates offers to guide the self-improvement of a younger man. The context for self-examination is pedagogical. But there is also an old tradition which places self-care within medical thought and practice (Foucault, 1986: 54ff.). So there were two powerful metaphorical frameworks within which the self concept could develop: in the pedagogical metaphor the self appeared as a locus of ignorance and confusion, as the object of training and instruction; in the medical metaphor the self appeared as a locus of illness, feebleness and vulnerability which became the object of treatment.

What these social contexts provided were points of view from which one's own actions could be examined. The injunction to reflect on one's actions would imply nothing more than the reinforcement of traditional mores if it were not joined to a broader framework within which the examination was to take place. Metaphors derived from pedagogical and medical practice provided a cognitive framework within which individuals, and not just their actions, could become objects to themselves.

Once this happens, there is often a tendency to separate out and to reify a part of the person that is thought of as the special repository of goodness and wisdom. One can see this quite clearly in the interaction of Socrates and Alcibiades already referred to. 'I wish that you would

explain to me in what way I am to take care of myself,' asks Alcibiades (Jowett, 1892: 503), and Socrates replies by invoking a metaphor that is to recur again and again in subsequent discourse about the self, right up to the present day. It is the metaphor of the mirror. Socrates likens a person getting to know himself to an eye seeing itself, and this can only be accomplished with a mirror. But only a very special mirror will do, namely, the eye of another person. 'Then if the eye is to see itself, it must look at the eye, and at that part of the eye where sight which is the virtue of the eye resides' (Jowett, 1892: 505). What Socrates suggests is that just as the virtue of sight resides in a special organ, the eye, so moral virtue resides in a special part of the person. If one wishes to improve the moral quality of one's life one must examine this special part and not simply the sum total of one's worldly deeds. In other words, a part of the person has now been categorized as an abiding object of observation and intervention for both self and others.

In this discourse persons have certainly become objects for themselves. But we must be careful not to confuse this state of affairs with the modern concept of the self. First of all, we miss any concern with what would become an obsession in the modern period: the question of individuality, of the unique qualities that establish personal identity and distinguish individuals from each other. The virtue which resides in the Ancients' soul is not its capacity for fully realizing its unique self, its individualized potential, but rather its possibility of discovering and tuning in to the order inherent in the world.

Secondly, we find that the classical writers look for the expression of the personal core, not in the private or the inner life of the individual, as we moderns are inclined to do, but in his public life. In the late classical period there are exceptions to this, especially among the Stoics, who advocated periodic retreats from the world as a way of getting in touch with oneself. But overall, the classical era does not draw the division between a public and a private sphere with anything like the sharpness that we are used to. For these reasons there are definite limits to the development of 'technologies of the self' during this period. Auto-biographies, for example, are virtually unknown, and the few existing examples of the genre do not take as their object a unique private self that persists over the life span (Weintraub, 1978).

The social contexts to which we have traced an emerging self-objectification do not contain prominent religious elements. This does not mean that such elements were absent, only that they did not define the meaning of these situations in the way they defined the meaning of explicitly religious practices, rituals, etc. Nor does it mean that a kind of self-objectification did not develop in a religious context. But the differences between the latter and modern naturalistic concepts of the person have long been recognized. It is when they are at their most naturalistic that the Ancients become attractive as progenitors of our own naturalism. Unfortunately, this affinity can all too easily lead us to

mistake their naturalism for ours. Our naturalism has become intimately tied up with physicalism of a kind that originates in a rigorous separation of the physical and the mental, of body and consciousness. That separation was utterly foreign to the classical literature. Accordingly, there was no distinction between 'primary', physical, attributes of things and 'secondary', mental attributes. Aesthetic and moral qualities could be as much part of the objective world order as physical qualities. There was no lining up of the objective and physical on one side of a great divide against the subjective and mental on the other. This is reflected in the Aristotelian category of reason to which we must now turn.

Reason

Aristotle made a fundamental division between those characteristics of the human *psyche* which it shared with the *psyche* of other living things and those which were peculiar to humanity. His Latin translators and commentators generally rendered the latter by the term *intellectus*. This usage survived into the early modern period via Aristotelian scholasticism. 'Intellect' was a specifically human attribute, fundamentally different from anything to be found at the non-human level. It was not unusual for this attribute to be identified with the human capacities for logical inference, conceptual thinking and abstraction.

However, the crucial point is that this category could refer both to a rational order of things and to the human capacity for understanding that order. The Greek term *nous*, which had been translated by the Latin *intellectus*, had defined something in the human soul that participated in objective reason (*logos*), the rational order of the world. We still get a faint echo of this notion in early modern references to the creator of the universe as the 'divine intelligence'. Such theological interpretations were based on a more general figure of thought that united in one category a human capacity and the features of the world upon which it was exercised. Aristotle considered that although

being an act of thinking and being an object of thought are not the same . . . in some cases the knowledge is the object. In the productive sciences . . . the substance in the sense of essence, and in the theoretical sciences the formula or the act of thinking, is the object. As then thought and the object of thought are not different in the case of things that have not matter, they will be the same, i.e. the thinking will be one with the object of its thought. (Aristotle, 1984, II: 1698–1699)

The objects of *nous* were the fundamental principles according to which the world was constructed. To the individual intelligence there corresponded the 'intelligible objects' of the world, and with the exercise of that intelligence these objects lived in the individual. There could be no understanding of *nous* without an understanding of the objects that

gave it content. The classical, Aristotelian, notion of intellect depended on a belief in a 'right' and necessary order of the world. The principles of that order were to be distinguished from matters of empirical contingency, things that might also have turned out differently. Only insofar as these principles were glimpsed by an individual could individual intelligence be said to be operating.

As we will see in the next chapter, a very different conception of reason replaces the Aristotelian conception in the modern period. A purely instrumental understanding of intellectual activity supervenes. What reason can do is to find the best means for achieving an individual's ends, not to discover the best ends. In this scheme there is no counterpart to the classical conception of *nous*. Rationality is not something that can be attributed to the world, only to individuals. Things just are the way they are, though people are equipped to make the best of them. In due course this equipment would be attributed to individuals' biological constitution, but for this attribution to be made it was first necessary for people to get used to thinking of the intellect as a piece of equipment, an instrument like an arm or a leg, to be employed in the service of individual ends. Such a notion would have seemed strange indeed to someone accustomed to the classical perspective.

From that perspective the modern conception of intelligence, based as it is on the prior notion of the instrumentality of reason, would seem to involve a loss of the crucial distinction between intelligence and mere cleverness. If we allow the translation of *nous* as intelligence, some such distinction is already to be found in Aristotle, who also recognizes another human quality, *deinotes*, which is generally translated as cleverness. Now, *deinotes*, defined as 'the power to perform those steps which are conducive to a goal we have set for ourselves and to attain that goal' (Aristotle, 1962: 1144a25) sounds suspiciously like the modern conception of instrumental reason. The merely clever person may know how to choose the most effective means to achieve a given end but is a fool when it comes to the rational evaluation of the ends themselves. Of course this is not how we would expect the Aristotelian *nous* to manifest itself. But even *nous* has its limitations. It is defined by the understanding of abstractions, of 'first principles', and fine though this was, Aristotle knew that there was a lot more to living intelligently than that. So other distinctions have to be introduced. One of these leads to a category that is clearly related to some of the everyday rather than the scientific uses of 'intelligence'. This is the category of *phronesis*, which has no equivalent in modern English usage.

Unlike the inhabitants of Greek city states, the monks who interpreted the categories of Greek philosophy in the Middle Ages tended to be preoccupied with theoretical rather than practical or political intelligence. Later scholars often had similar inclinations, and so there developed a curious division between academic writings on the topic of

the 'intellectual' faculties and everyday usage to which the term 'intelligence' was consigned – 'abandoned to the psychology of the streets,' as Charles Spearman (1923: 19) put it rather suggestively.² (He saw himself as the noble rescuer who would bestow academic respectability upon this poor waif.) However, if we go back to the classical sources we find quite another evaluation of the practical intellect. Human excellence could be displayed in action as much as in abstraction, and in either case its achievement required the operation of rationality. But not in the same way. Theorizing in science and philosophy proceeds from particulars to abstractions, but human action always occurs in particular situations, so that even the most marvellous abstractions do not necessarily help us to act well. For that we have to have a capacity for responding appropriately to particular cases, we have to have 'good sense', the term which some of Aristotle's translators think comes closest to *phronesis*. Whereas *nous*, the prototype for the later category of intellect, involved insight into matters that often had no obvious social character, e.g. mathematical abstractions, *phronesis* was inherently social. The paradigmatic example for the exercise of *phronesis* was political action. Perhaps that is why the term had no appeal to later generations whose experience of politics left a lot less room for good sense than had Athenian democracy.

In everyday usage, however, the attribute 'intelligent' has come to be applied in ways that recall the concept of *phronesis*. It is quite appropriate to speak of an intelligent policy, of someone making an intelligent decision, of handling a situation intelligently. One of the reasons for the scepticism that the twentieth-century psychological concept of intelligence often encountered among the lay public was its apparent failure to cover such cases.

The distinction between theoretical intellect and practical good sense is only a small part of a complex network of concepts within which Aristotelian theorizing attempted to capture the essential meaning of the kind of talk about human excellence that was familiar to its audience (see Reeve, 1992: ch. 2; Sparshott, 1994: 196–237). Among the most fertile of these concepts were *sophia* (wisdom) and *techné*, involved in the making or production of things. Another interesting distinction was that between the part of the rational soul that reasons for itself and the part that merely listens to reason. Natural slaves have the latter but not the former.

The Aristotelian conception of reason opens up a vast domain of which I have merely presented glimpses.³ These should suffice to convey an impression of a rich conceptual landscape whose features and contours are quite different from what we find in modern psychology. As late as the seventeenth century, an essentially Aristotelian conceptual network still defined intellectual orthodoxy when it came to reflection on human reason. It provides the background against which the significant features of modern developments should be highlighted.

Aristotelian affections

Earlier on, we followed Foucault in noting that in the self-care practices of antiquity individuals became objects of their own regard. Within such a context, concepts of the human person had necessarily to be dual in character. On the one hand, there had to be concepts that would make intelligible the individual's desire for improvement, for better understanding, for taking care. Such concepts generally referred to the individual's rationality. But on the other hand, it was also necessary to conceive of aspects of the individual which were the object of improvement, the targets of control. These aspects came to be known as the affections, or passions. They were experienced as things that happened to people, things that could grip them, in spite of their better rational judgement.

In the Aristotelian texts, such aspects of the person are discussed in three different places, supplying three different contexts: the *Rhetoric*, the (Nicomachean) *Ethics*, and the book *On the Soul*.⁴ When we compare these texts, we find that each of them treats the topic in a different way. In each case the discursive context determines the content.

The *Rhetoric* is devoted to the principles of persuasion, either in a court of law or in a political forum. For this purpose it discusses 'the emotions [which] are all those feelings that so change men as to affect their judgements, and that are also attended by pain or pleasure' (Aristotle, 1984: II, 2195). So here the criterion for grouping certain things together is that they all affect people's judgement. There is an implicit distinction between judgements and certain feelings which affect them. The Aristotelian text enumerates these feelings, mostly giving them a bipolar character. Thus we get anger–calmness, friendship–enmity, fear–confidence, shame–shamelessness, kindness–unkindness, pity–indignation, as well as envy and emulation. The choice of 'emotions' is governed by what is considered useful to the public orator, but so is the distinction between judgements and what affects them. Institutionalized forms have defined the space within which the orator has to operate. Certain acts of decision making have been institutionally separated from the process of deliberation preceding them. The public orator is permitted to intervene only during the earlier phase but tries to influence what happens in the second phase. A text on the art of rhetoric should provide him (no women allowed) with a conceptual scheme for organizing his actions within this institutional space, and this is what Aristotle's *Rhetoric* is designed to do.

In the *Nicomachean Ethics* the discursive context is quite different. A very specific practical interest has now been replaced by a more general one. The parts of this text that would strike the modern reader as 'psychological' are addressed to 'the student of politics'. Such a person, we are told, should know something about the soul, just as one 'who is to heal the eyes must know about the whole body also' (Aristotle, 1984:

II, 1741). The reference to healing makes it clear that practical concerns have not disappeared, but they are now considerably broader than the narrow goals of the orator. A more general question – how to achieve ‘excellence’ (or ‘virtue’, as the older translations would have it) – now determines the agenda.

As a consequence, it is noticed that there are certain things which sometimes prevent us from achieving excellence or virtue in spite of ourselves. The analogy of a ‘paralysed’ limb is invoked – its owner wants to move it to the right, yet it moves to the left. So there are elements of the soul which go their own uncontrolled way. Some of these elements have to do with processes of nurture and growth which we are powerless to influence at all. Then there are elements which we are able to control to some extent, like passions and desires. The distinction is therefore between human ‘reason’, which aspires to the good life, and other elements in the soul which must be regulated if the good life is to be achieved. According to Aristotle, the ideal is not the suppression of the passions but their expression in moderation. In modern terms, we would have to say that ‘reason’, no less than the passions, is endowed with ‘motivational’ attributes. There is a natural striving for excellence or virtue, for the good life, for happiness, just as there are particular desires which at times interfere with this striving. The distinction is one between different kinds of striving (*orexis*), not between striving and something else.

A major difference between the rhetorical and the ethical context is worth noting. Both are essentially practical in nature, but whereas in the *Rhetoric* Aristotle was concerned with ways of influencing *others*, in the *Ethics* he is much more interested in improving the *self*. That clearly determines the way in which individual striving is conceptualized. The public persuader gets what he needs – a finite list of specific human qualities that he can work on. For the person seeking moral enlightenment, however, such a list is of little help because, as Aristotle points out, moral judgements are not made on the basis of natural qualities but on the basis of excellence or virtue. So the ethically interested person is taught to think of almost any quality in terms of the opposition between reasonable moderation and unreasonable excess (or sometimes deficiency). Later on, that ethical opposition would become reified in terms of a conflict between the rational and the irrational part of the human person.

In another discursive context Aristotle himself introduces some such distinction, but the scheme he presents is different from the ethical one. In the work *On the Soul* there are no practical considerations. This time the only professed interest is in the truth about the soul as such, so we are presented with yet another scheme of classification, a scheme that derives from Aristotle’s beliefs about what the Greeks called *psyche*. This entity has no modern equivalent and is certainly not to be confused with the Christian soul or the post-Christian mind (Sorabji, 1979). For

Aristotle, the possession of *psyche* distinguished the living from the non-living, so that it was to be found in plants and animals as well as in humans. However, in his book on *psyche* (traditionally rendered by the Latin *anima* or the later 'soul') Aristotle is concerned with the differences between the 'souls' of plants, animals, and humans. The underlying question that gives direction to this inquiry is one about the place of humans in the world of nature.

Aristotle lays the ground for answering this question by distinguishing between five 'powers' of *psyche*. These are: the power of absorbing nourishment for growth, the power of sensing, the power of movement, the power of appetite (desiring), and the power of thinking. The 'souls' of plants have only the first of these powers, most animals have the next three, and only the human soul has all five (Aristotle, 1984: I, 658ff.). Thus the distinction between cognition and desire serves to establish the superior status of humans in the order of nature.

What makes this scheme quite different from modern arguments with a similar practical outcome – Descartes' for example – is its metaphysical basis. The natural 'powers' that Aristotle worked with are not at all like the physical machinery of the moderns. Every such power has an inbuilt tendency towards a certain state or end, a certain 'appetite' or directed striving. The power of vision, for example, strives for exposure to visible things, the power of locomotion includes a spontaneous tendency to move, and the power of thought implies actually engaging in thinking whenever possible. *There is no separate category of 'motivation' in this scheme.* That category only became necessary when all psychological activity came to be classified as a kind of mechanism, analogous to inert physical machinery. Such a mechanism *always* needs a push or 'motive' to get it going. That was introduced in the eighteenth century, as we will see in the next chapter. In analysing activity, the Aristotelian scheme did not separate out a mechanical action component and an energizing component. What lay behind activity were certain 'powers' that were as much energizing as they were enabling. The power of thinking was no different. It implied a tendency to reason that did not require a separate motive to get it going. The power of appetite did not act like a source of mechanical pushes for all the other powers. It involved a tendency to seek whatever constituted 'the good' for the creature. In the case of humans, that included moral goods which were objective, as much part of the order of the world as the objects required by animals for their survival. In Christian versions of this scheme the category of 'the will' was often invoked here.

Some post-Aristotelian themes

In the post-Aristotelian literature of antiquity 'affections', or 'passions', were assigned a different place in the make-up of the individual. The moral teaching of Stoicism, in particular, emphasized rigorous self-

control, rather than Aristotelian moderation. The things to be controlled were now systematically conceptualized as a separate class of undesirable 'movements of the soul'.⁵ Four basic passions were recognized: pleasure, pain, fear, and desire. The Greek concept of *pathos*, applied to things that one underwent or suffered, had been given a philosophical interpretation by Aristotle as one of the ten basic categories of existence. It also had a more specific meaning. The passions could distort the normal functioning of the person. They were even thought of as a kind of disease of the soul. For the Stoics, the unity and rationality of the soul remained paramount. Passions were still beliefs or judgements, so that the opposition was not between cognition and passion, but between natural and unnatural expressions of the soul. In the Stoic view: 'we are responsible for our emotions, just as we are for our more considered actions' (Annas, 1992: 116).

Mediaeval Christian theology elaborated its own doctrine of the powers of the soul, reinterpreting the classical authors to suit a different agenda. In particular, the opposition between sensuous and intellectual striving and between endured passion and active will became entangled with the opposition between flesh and spirit. St Thomas Aquinas held that the sensuous appetites, or passions, were not attributes of the (immortal) soul as such, but only affected the soul insofar as it was tied to the body. That idea incorporated a long tradition of blaming the body for feelings that were unwelcome yet hard to control, a tradition that was to survive in secular form right up to the twentieth century.

Scholastic doctrine is also notable for its systematizing efforts. In the writings of St Thomas Aquinas (1947) these led to an elaborate classificatory network which assigned a proper place to such diverse experiences as hope, despair, fear, courage, desire, pain, love, aversion, and several others. All these were 'passions'. The practical interest in controlling human experience and conduct is still prominent – Thomas rates them all as either good or evil. But there is also a pronounced effort at conceptual control. The labels for the passions are lifted from their place in ordinary usage and caught in the scholar's finite nomological net where they are assigned their systematic place. Backed by the institutional power of the Church, there now existed an authoritative doctrine which could be used to instruct people about how they were to regard their affective life.

As late as the seventeenth century, there are few basic changes in this doctrine. Descartes' *The Passions of the Soul*, published in 1649, is notable for its total separation of soul and body and its mechanistic view of the latter (Descartes, 1931). That radicalizes the existing tendency to make the body responsible for the passions. The latter are now simply experiences of the soul caused by the body. A new opposition comes to define the passions. The 'passions of the soul', originating in the body, are now distinguished from the 'actions of the soul', which depend solely on the soul itself and owe nothing to the body. These 'actions' are

described as 'all our desires', and they include acts of will resulting in overt behaviour as well as pure thoughts. The passions include 'perceptions' of bodily appetites, like hunger and thirst, as well as 'feelings or emotions' caused by the body. For Descartes, there could also be perceptions, feelings and emotions that do not originate in the body but in the soul. He therefore employs two principles of classification, one experiential, the other metaphysical. Experientially, we know the difference between perceptions and feelings, and we also refer them either to the outside world or to ourselves. But, metaphysically, there is a fundamental distinction between experiences originating in the body and experiences originating in the soul. Descartes' metaphysical criterion enjoyed a strong revival two centuries after it was first proposed. The effects of that revival were still prominent in twentieth-century conceptions of the emotions.

In many respects, Descartes' treatment of the 'passions' followed tradition. He disagreed with St Thomas' classification and offered his own, deriving all the passions from six primitive ones: wonder, love, hatred, desire, joy and sadness. However, he clearly shared the conviction that passions were distinct entities to be caught in a classificatory net like animal specimens. His book on the passions was based on his earlier correspondence with Princess Elizabeth of the Palatinate, a political refugee who looked to him for advice on how to cope with the difficulties of her personal situation. He also sent the book to Queen Christina of Sweden, another troubled soul whom he was counselling at the time. As in the past, Descartes' conceptualization of the passions is embedded in a context of moral concern. The passions are that which must be controlled if the good life is to be achieved. They are assigned their place by the fundamental opposition between a superior part of the individual which does the controlling and an unruly inferior part which ought to be controlled. Descartes, however, refuses to identify these parts as higher and lower layers of the soul. Only the superior part is soul; the inferior part is body.⁶ The passions had always been undesirable within the soul, but now their causes are banished to a nether region outside the soul.

Note that passions now have *causes*. There is a hypothetical chain of physical causes and effects within the body involved in their generation. And if the rational will does not intervene, this chain of efficient causes extends to the skeletal musculature and results in motor activity which Descartes does not distinguish from action. If one acted purely under the influence of a passion one's behaviour would be quite mechanical. Descartes' rigid mind-body dualism introduced a fundamental division between *voluntary* and *involuntary* action that was not like anything recognized in the classical literature. In this respect, his work on the passions certainly marked the beginning of a new period.

Let us briefly note the main points that have emerged so far. First of all, it is clear that there was a strong element of continuity in European

discourse regarding such phenomena as desire, joy and aversion. For many centuries, such topics tended to be discussed in a context of moral concern dominated by a fundamental opposition between one part of the individual that was higher, better and in charge, and another part that was a source of unhappiness and evil, and that must be kept in control. This was a discourse that aimed to inform people about their own nature in such a way as to facilitate their self-management within given social circumstances. One of the ways in which this worked was through the provision of schemes of classification that would enable people to label and identify their experiences in a manner appropriate to the goal of moral control. Because they were arbitrary, there was never any agreement on the labels covered by these schemes, and there certainly was nothing remotely resembling the twentieth-century distinction between emotion and motivation. What was much more important than the specific content was the mere existence of such schemes and the fundamental polarity between the ruling and the ruled over parts of the individual. Those were the features which ensured the serviceability and survival of conceptions that converged on aspects of humanity characterized as non-rational.

Notes

1. For pursuing many of the issues briefly touched on in the present chapter, as well as related topics, the extensive bibliography in Everson (1991) will be found very useful.
2. Possibly this was encouraged by the devaluation of 'intelligence' implied in St Thomas Aquinas' (1947, I: 405) observation that this form is found in translations from the Arabic, whereas 'intellect' is found in translations from the Greek.
3. For a topical discussion of some of the complexities of ancient conceptions of human and animal reason, as well as references to relevant secondary sources, see Sorabji (1993).
4. There are also brief allusions in the *Topics* which need not be considered here.
5. See Gardiner et al. (1970) for details. On general issues regarding 'the passions', see Solomon (1976).
6. 'For there is within us but one soul, and this soul has not in itself any diversity of parts; the same part that is subject to sense impressions is rational; and all the soul's appetites are acts of will. The error which has been committed in making it play the part of various personages, usually in opposition one to another, only proceeds from the fact that we have not properly distinguished its functions from those of the body, to which alone we must attribute every thing which can be observed in us that is opposed to our reason' (Descartes, 1931: 353).

THE GREAT TRANSFORMATION

Many of the fundamental categories of twentieth-century psychology are, to all intents and purposes, twentieth-century inventions. Such concepts as 'intelligence', 'personality', 'behaviour' and 'learning' were given such radically changed meanings by modern psychology that there simply are no earlier equivalents. In other cases, for example 'motivation' or 'social attitudes', the use of the terms themselves was new, describing previously unsuspected phenomenal domains. The coming of modern psychology was associated with a revolutionary restructuring of the network of categories employed in the conceptualization of human experience and conduct.

But not everything was changed. Certain, unquestionably psychological, categories were retained with little or no change in meaning from an earlier period. Concepts like 'emotion', 'motive' (which is not 'motivation'), 'consciousness' or 'self-esteem' made the transition to the modern period without any radical change in meaning. The existence of this more venerable group points to an older layer of psychological concepts that antedated the emergence of Psychology as a discipline. Of course, this older layer also contained such prominent categories as 'will' and 'character' which did not survive the transition to a scientific psychology. Why then did one group survive and another not?

The answer proposed here is that the survivors were part of a categorical network whose basic features were bequeathed to modern psychology by an earlier period. To use an archaeological analogy: in constructing its domain, modern Psychology used building blocks from older settlements insofar as these were still serviceable under the new conditions. However, the image of building blocks is perhaps misleading. It would be more appropriate to speak of foundations. For it was not a pile of disconnected conceptual units that was taken over but a lattice of interconnected parts. In the present chapter we will describe some of the historical roots of these foundations.

Eighteenth-century novelties

If we try to trace back the meaning of the older psychological categories that are still in systematic use today we quickly lose the trail once we go